

Tightning the net

Not taking any more chance, Google announced HTTPS will be activated by default for Gmail soon

McAfee and Facebook

Not to be left behind, Facebook has partnered with McAfee to instill confidence in its 300 million userbase

TIPS TO STAY SAFE ONLINE

If you missed out on the list of security features to identify a trustworthy web site, have a look at this quick checklist.

1. Avoid following links when it comes to shopping online. Always key in your own URL. It is better not to follow search engines when it comes to transacting online.
2. Never share any personal or financial information on a non-secure web site.
3. Always personally verify email pleas to donate or plans of earning a quick fortune (even if it be from a known person).
4. Always ensure your transactions occur with an encrypted connection.
5. Look out for a golden lock on the bottom of the screen, and https: in the address bar.
6. When online users equipped with current versions of Internet Explorer, Firefox, Safari, Google Chrome, Opera and other browsers visit a site protected by EV SSL Certificates, the top address bar turns green and displays the name of the company operating the web site. This green bar offers immediate reassurance that they've reached a site whose authenticity has been verified by a certificate authority such as VeriSign, the world's leading EV SSL certificate provider.
7. Never respond to emails of urgency. They're usually phishing.
8. Block all spam emails you receive.
9. Regularly login to your online banking accounts to check for any suspicious activity.
10. Do not sync your financial passwords with your regular email passwords.
11. When using a public computer, restrict browsing to information-only web sites such as news sites. Avoid accessing any e-banking, e-brokerage, e-commerce web sites that require you to divulge personal information such as usernames or passwords.
12. Never store usernames and passwords in Internet Explorer
13. Use an up-to-date anti-virus program, and ask the cyber cafe attendant on a public computer to check the toolbar to ensure it is safe.
14. Always logout from transactional web sites to be sure your safety will not be compromised after you have left the system.
15. Finally, clear browsing history and cookies after your session.

Source: Deepa Thomas and Rajiv Chadha

SIGNED. This needs to be taken seriously, as the signature is a low tech first line of defense against credit card misuse. However it needs to be implemented to be effective. Do merchant establishments that have card swiping machines, ever match signatures? We decided to put this to test at some of the biggest technology stores in the hope that we'd be proved wrong. We chose large technology retail chains based on a simple logic — outfits dealing in high value products that are on the cutting edge of technology, need to uphold technological safeguards right? We created several scenarios to test real world security measures in the area of electronic transactions. Two digit team members went to four different electronics retail stores throughout Mumbai. At their disposal, were two debit cards, both of which were unsigned. In fact one was a photo id card. This is worth mentioning because two operatives couldn't look have looked so unlike each other even if they tried. When the undercover operatives used the cards they made no attempt at forging the signature of the card holder. Instead they simply signed their own names.

Target 1:

Reliance Digital Store, Vashi

The store had very few customers and there was no queue near the payment counter. We used the unsigned card at this location. The clerk behind the counter went about completing the transaction without bothering to even flip over the card to verify signatures (in this

case there was none). The name that was signed was drastically different from the one that appeared on the card.

Alertness — Nil

Target 2:

Tata Croma, Vashi, Navi Mumbai

Here we used a signed debit card. The counter person had the card with him for quite a while but there was no effort to verify the signatures. As soon as the printed slip was signed the slip was returned without any kind of verification.

Alertness — Nil

Target 3:

eZone, Bombay Central

Here we used a photo debit card. Strangely, the card was in the possession of the counter staff for close to five minutes. In the whole time, no one bothered to look up and verify the photograph. The counter person noticed however that there was no sign on the rear of the card and asked the customer to sign it, but the matter wasn't enforced. Although in this case the staff was slightly more alert than the other times, it was only pointed out after the transaction was completely over.

Alertness — Somewhat

Target 4:

Tata Croma, Lower Parel

Here again we used the unsigned card with the photo id. Neither the signature nor the photo was verified at any point of time. There was no sort of verification whatsoever. The transaction was quick.

Alertness — Nil

Implications

This raises a lot of questions. Are merchant outlets so eager to effect a sale that they don't really care where the money comes from? Besides, what are the protections in place for the consumer if his card is stolen and purchases are made from the card. Abroad, if the card is stolen and used, the credit card company reverses the charge (once the user complains) and the merchant has to prove that the owner of the card actually used it. If the merchant cannot prove it then he has to pay a heavy fine. The credit card user is protected as long as he reports the

BE THE WISE CONSUMER

As Arun Saxena President, International Consumer Rights Protection Council advises "always read the fine print. Rather than being driven by your instinct to own a credit card, remember the interest rates associated with credit." A smart tip he gives us is to strike out points that could be used against us on the printed agreement. As he puts it, credit card companies live on consumers defaults, without which they wouldn't be able to survive in this competitive market."

Avoid shopping for high value products from online shopping web sites that you don't trust, as you can never be sure of the final product being delivered. Saxena feels "for low value items, ebay seems to be a good web site because your payments are safe through PaisaPay. But it is preferable to buy from a mall as you can touch, feel, and see the colour and working of the unit you are buying."

He adds, "Keep your credit card account, Savings account and Loan account in different banks so that they cannot take out money from another account."